

Psalms 23

The Lord My Shepherd

The Lord is my shepherd; I shall not want

KJV · Standalone study handout

1 · THE WORD (KJV)

- 1 *The LORD is my shepherd; I shall not want.*
- 2 *He maketh me to lie down in green pastures: he leadeth me beside the still waters.*
- 3 *He restoreth my soul: he leadeth me in the paths of righteousness for his name's sake.*
- 4 *Yea, though I walk through the valley of the shadow of death, I will fear no evil: for thou art with me; thy rod and thy staff they comfort me.*
- 5 *Thou preparest a table before me in the presence of mine enemies: thou anointest my head with oil; my cup runneth over.*
- 6 *Surely goodness and mercy shall follow me all the days of my life: and I will dwell in the house of the LORD for ever.*

2 · CONTEXT

Perhaps the most beloved psalm, Psalm 23 pictures God under two tender images—shepherd guiding a sheep, and host welcoming a guest—covering provision, guidance, danger, and hospitality within six compact verses. Henry notes its intensely personal tone (“my shepherd,” not merely “a” or “the” shepherd of Israel generally) and its movement from pastoral care in green pastures to protection in the darkest valley to festive welcome at a prepared table, ending in a settled hope of dwelling with God forever.

3 · VERSE-BY-VERSE COMMENTARY

The notes below cover the whole chapter in one place—read with the KJV text above.

Verse 1-3

The Lord as shepherd meets total need (“I shall not want”), providing rest in green pastures, leading beside still waters, restoring the soul, and guiding in right paths for His own name’s sake—care that is comprehensive and reputation-bound to God’s own character.

Verse 4

Even walking through “the valley of the shadow of death,” fear is refused because “thou art with me”; rod and staff—tools of correction and guidance—become instruments of comfort rather than threat in the shepherd’s hand.

Verse 5-6

The image shifts to a host’s table prepared in the very presence of enemies, head anointed, cup overflowing—abundant provision and dignity amid opposition. The psalm closes with confident expectation that goodness and mercy will follow all of life, ending in dwelling in the Lord’s house forever.

4 · MEANING & APPLICATION

Meaning.

God’s care as shepherd and host is comprehensive—meeting practical need, guiding through danger without removing it, and providing dignity and abundance even before enemies—grounding a lifelong hope of dwelling with Him.

Application for life today.

Personalize the psalm by naming your current “valley” and specifically trusting the shepherd’s presence rather than demanding its removal. Notice where God has prepared a “table”—provision and dignity—even in circumstances surrounded by opposition, and receive it gratefully instead of only fixating on the enemies. Let the closing confidence (“goodness and mercy shall follow me”) become a daily, not just a funeral, verse—rehearse it as present-tense hope.

5 · REFLECT & RESPOND

Write your answers in the space below. There are no “right length” answers—honesty before God is the aim.

1. What “valley of the shadow of death” are you currently walking through, and how does “thou art with me” speak to it?

2. Where might God be preparing a “table” of provision for you even amid opposition or difficulty?

3. How would truly believing “goodness and mercy shall follow me all the days of my life” change your outlook today?

Name: _____ Date: _____ Group / Church: _____

Sources: King James Version (public domain); Matthew Henry, *Commentary on the Whole Bible* (themes summarized); Expository themes consistent with MacArthur Study Bible tradition (paraphrased, not quoted). Scripture: King James Version (public domain).